did not agree with it. ‘This idea will not work,’ he continued. ‘I have serious reservations about the practicability of the concept, and further deliberations are going to be a waste of time,’ he added, looking at the army and corps commanders. Thereafter, an argument started between him and the GOC, Major General Mayadas. There was consternation on our faces as the drama unfolded itself in the elaborately prepared sand model room that had an excellent three-dimensional depiction of the entire area. Realizing that the ugly episode was causing embarrassment to all, particularly the younger lot of officers, the army commander ordered a halt to the proceedings.

The GOC announced a tea break. We dispersed while the brass went into a huddle. After a suspenseful hour or so, we were assembled in the sand model room and told that the discussion had been terminated. We were stunned. Such an abrupt end to an important training event was unprecedented – nor did it happen again in my career! The august gathering was then informed that an exercise with troops would be conducted on the ground soon, to decide on the feasibility and viability of the concept. Further, my brigade commander was tasked to run that exercise under the directions of the GOC of the division. Brigadier Airy had an enthusiastic, intelligent and professionally sound brigade major, Deepak Summanwar – a happy-go-lucky and warm-hearted young man. He was a friend of mine, and would go out of his way to see that my battalion got a fair deal. At the same time, I sought no favours.

We returned to our units and awaited further instructions. I was sad to leave because Rohini and the kids were staying in army accommodation in Dinjan, and I had been looking forward to spending a few days with them. Alas, it was not to be!

A month or two later I received a call from the general staff officer (operations) of our division, Lieutenant Colonel G.S. Uban, as in those days there were no colonel general staff.

‘The GOC,’ he said, ‘has decided that your battalion will carry out the task of mobile defence of a given area in the forthcoming exercise, and hence, he would like to discuss the matter with you’.